

Drop Carrier

Starting April 2003, the Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (TRAI) has recommended that the duration of local calls from fixed phone lines be reduced from 3 minutes to 2 minutes. This has far-reaching implications for dial-up Internet users, as their telephone charges will increase substantially under this new pulse rate plan.

Modem users in India pay a dual charge for accessing the Internet: first, for using the infrastructure of their fixed line telecom operator to access their ISP's network (your modem connects to your ISP's modem via BSNL/MTNL's phone lines), and secondly, the subscription fees of the ISPs themselves. What this means is that you could now end up paying Rs 36 per hour as telephone charges alone, apart from your regular Internet access fees!

However, in order to avert the expected backlash from dial-up Internet users, TRAI has increased the off-peak hours, during which ISPs will provide discounted rates, from 8:00 PM to 8:00 AM. But they haven't specified the level of concession to be offered and have left it on the ISPs to decide what benefits the end users will receive.

This is quite obviously a patch-up solution and TRAI knows it.

The actual problem for dial-up Internet users lies within the telecommunication tariff structure itself. Most dial-up Internet users fall into the category of heavy network users, as they utilise the telecom operator's network for extended periods of time. If TRAI were to introduce a tariff structure, which benefits extended use, then telecom operators might face the precarious situation of their networks being congested by a larger number of simultaneous users who would then find it economical to make calls of longer duration. This would force the telecom operators to upgrade their backend infrastructure, in order to support their existing users, which effectively throws any suggestion of a reduction in call rates out of the window!

Previously, opting for an always-on broadband connection, like cable or DSL, made perfect sense for hardcore Internet junkies. But usage patterns are not important any more, as dial-up Internet isn't cost-effective, not even for casual surfers who use the Internet for only 30-45 minutes a day.

Also, with most cellular operators ramping up their networks for 3G, wireless Internet is an option worth considering. Reliance and TATA use CDMA 2000 1X technology, which means they can offer data connectivity speeds of up to 144 kbps. Hutch/Orange and BPL Mobile already offer GPRS connectivity on their networks.

The bottom line is this: if you use a modem to access the Internet, it's time to re-evaluate your options. The good news is that there are plenty of options to choose from, be it cable, DSL or wireless.



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